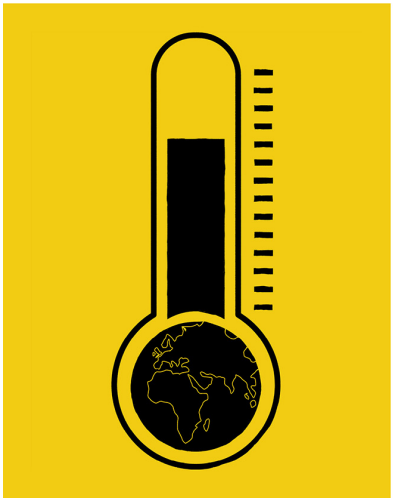


IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

Svante Arrhenius (1859–1927)

BEFORE

1824 French physicist Joseph Fourier suggests that Earth's atmosphere traps the Sun's heat like a greenhouse.

1859 Irish physicist John Tyndall provides experimental evidence to support earlier hypotheses that atmospheric gases absorb radiant heat.

AFTER

1976 American scientist Charles Keeling proves that between 1959 and 1971 carbon dioxide levels in the atmosphere increased by about 3.4 percent each year.

2006 In *Field Notes from a Catastrophe*, journalist Elizabeth Kolbert tells the stories of people and places impacted by climate change.

In 1896, Swedish chemist Svante Arrhenius became the first person to argue that carbon dioxide (CO_2) emissions caused by human beings could lead to global warming. Arrhenius thought that the average ground temperature could be influenced by carbon dioxide and other "greenhouse gases," as they are now known, and believed that increasing levels of CO_2 would raise